



'MALFUNCTIONING PHANTASMAGORIA'
Watercolor on paper by MANIL GUPTA

Six Steps TO NIRVANA

Accountability must
be the hallmark of
elected officials and the
unelected bureaucracy

— By **RAJEEV GOWDA**

I hope that the politics of the future will be like the politics of the past, where the stage is filled by leaders endowed with idealism, courage, vision, integrity, and character. India had such giants once, who led us to Independence and built our nation and our institutions. So my father and uncle, themselves freedom fighters, told me. That inspired me to resolve, at a young age, to become a politician and to do my bit for India.

This was not an ambition that many others shared. For, over time, politics had got tainted. Leaders had let us down. Parties rode to power through the politics of hate and division. Those who spoke compassionately of wiping the tear from every eye

failed to deliver. Many politicians' hands were either blackened by corruption or reddened through communal violence. Money and muscle began to dominate. Criminals felt right at home in legislatures. People despaired over whether our politics could ever improve.

Luckily for us, India is a blessed country. Like in the Hindu scriptures, where avatars

periodically emerge to cleanse and revive the system, we have seen the judiciary, the Election Commission, press, civil society, and politicians themselves step forward to set right the wrongs. So if we can identify what is wrong and imagine what we want to be, if we build and nurture institutions and cultural attitudes, I am confident that we will get there. In the spirit of